

# Political & Economic Thought — Master Notes

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One running document for the whole course, organised **by module**. Format per reading: **Résumé** → ★  
Heart of it → Key concepts → Section-by-section → Cases → Key terms → Exam pointers.

## Overview — where everything is

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(Everything below is clickable — jump straight to a week, reading, case, or fun-facts box.)

- **Module 1: Antiquity & the Middle Ages — Greeks & Romans** — ★ Lecture 1 (BAP/JL) · Reeve: Plato · McClelland: Aristotle · Galbraith intro · ★ Reading questions (answered) · ★ Fun facts
- **Module 2: Renaissance & Early-Modern — from Cosmopolis to Stato to Social Contract** — McClelland: Hobbes · Hobbes's social covenant · Grotius: natural law & the world system of states · Hobbes vs Grotius · ★ Fun facts

## Module 1: Antiquity and the Middle Ages — Greeks and Romans

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**Readings:** Reeve on Plato · McClelland on Aristotle · Galbraith intro (pp. 1–8)

**Theme of the module:** the two founders of Western political thought — **Plato** (the ideal state built on knowledge of the Good) and **Aristotle** (the empirical, "natural" study of the *polis*) — paired with Galbraith's framing of *how to read the history of economic ideas* (ideas as products of their time). Plato gives the **normative/idealist** pole, Aristotle the **empirical/naturalist** pole; both anchor every later debate.

★ **The red thread** — each text in **ONE idea** (keep these three in view; all the detail below hangs off them):

- **Reeve → Plato:** rule belongs to those who **KNOW the Good** — politics is *derived from metaphysics* (the philosopher-king in the kallipolis).
- **McClelland → Aristotle:** the **polis is natural**, studied **empirically** — judge every constitution by whose interest it serves (good vs corrupt; **politeia** = the best *practicable*).
- **Galbraith:** economic ideas are **products of their own time and place** — read ideas against the world that made them.

# ★ Lecture 1 (BAP/JL) — The roots of political philosophy

The lecture (Benjamin Ask Popp-Madsen · Joachim Lund) frames the whole field, then walks the ancient arc **Greece → Rome → early Christianity**. The readings below give the Plato/Aristotle/economics detail; this section adds the lecture's **framing** and the **Roman/Christian** material it covers beyond the readings. (Course/exam: written sit-in on CBS computers, Jan 2027; 7-step scale; two internal examiners.)

## | What is Political and Economic Thought? — theory vs. ideology

**Core:** both **theory** and **ideology** are "frameworks of explanation," but theory *aims at objectivity* (a **positive**, not normative, starting point — though never value-free), while ideology is openly **normative** — a programme for action.

- **Ideology** (Heywood): a coherent set of ideas grounding organised political action — it ① describes the existing order (a "world-view"), ② pictures a "good society," ③ says how to get from ①→②.
- **Theory:** rigorous concepts + logic aiming at some **objectivity**; a relatively rigorous (not strictly scientific) form of knowledge.
- So both sit on a **continuum between science and ideology** / positive vs normative. (Watch words like "right" and "just" — they sound like theory but smuggle in norms.)

## | Why study the history of ideas? — do ideas change the world?

**Core:** the course's central puzzle — do **ideas** move history, or do **material interests**?

- **Hegel:** "Philosophy comes too late to teach the world what it should be." • **Marx:** "philosophers have only *interpreted* the world; the point is to *change* it." • **Weber:** interests govern conduct, but the "world-images" created by ideas act like **switchmen** on the tracks. • **Gramsci** (*cultural hegemony*): the dominant ideas decide how socio-economic structures *can* be changed.

## | Three kinds of social theory

- **Political theory** — the **authoritative distribution of scarce resources** / the monopoly of violence.
- **Sociological theory** — human behaviour in and between groups.
- **Economic theory** — the **creation & distribution of wealth** (→ close to politics at the macro level, to sociology at the micro level).

## | Ancient Greece — the polis (context)

**Core:** the setting is the **polis** — the small, self-governing city-state — at its height ~500–400 BC, then eclipsed by Macedonian empire from **338 BC**.

- ~1,500 **Greek city-states**; typically 500–2,000 free adult male citizens each; **Athens** ~40,000 citizens (~200,000 total incl. women, children, slaves, metics).
- Democracy's arc: **Solon (594 BC)** & **Cleisthenes (508 BC)** extend citizenship → **Persian Wars** → **Peloponnesian War (431–404 BC, Athens defeated)** → **338 BC** Philip of Macedon ends Athenian

democracy → 322 BC Athens no longer independent (Aristotle dies that year).

## Plato & Aristotle — the lecture's framing

(Full detail in the Reeve and McClelland notes; here are the lecture's sharp contrasts.)

- **Plato** (427–347 BC): scarred by Athens' defeat (404) and **Socrates' execution (399)** → *unimpressed by democracy*. The kallipolis realises the Good; 3 soul-parts / 3 classes (producers = money-lovers · guardians = honour-lovers · philosopher-rulers = wisdom-lovers = "aristocracy").
- **Aristotle** (384–322 BC): a **foreigner (metic)** in Athens; **empiricist** — studied **150+ constitutions**; aims at **eudaimonia** (the good life); "identify those aspects of political life which operate **as nature intended**." Natural law reflected in human law; **natural pairs** (master–slave, husband–wife, father–child, ruler–ruled); some are "slaves by nature."
- **Aristotle's constitutions** — *in whose interest?* (the good/corrupt test):

| Rule by... | Common interest (just) | Rulers' interest (corrupt) |
|------------|------------------------|----------------------------|
| One        | Monarchy               | Tyranny                    |
| A few      | Aristocracy            | Oligarchy                  |
| Many       | <u>Politeia</u>        | Democracy                  |

- **Plato vs Aristotle in one line:** Plato asks "*which men are most able to govern?*" (from assumptions about human nature → rule by **sophia/wisdom**); Aristotle asks "*what would it take to be a good ruler?*" (from observation → **phronesis/practical wisdom**, plus **taking turns, accountability, legitimacy**). Aristotle distrusts rule by pure *sophia*.

## Politeia — Aristotle's best *practicable* constitution

**Core:** *politeia* (polity) = the good, common-interest form of rule by the many, and Aristotle's **best constitution actually achievable** for ordinary cities (a perfectly-virtuous monarch or aristocracy being rare). It is his real answer to "*who should rule?*"

- A "**mixed**" constitution: it **blends democracy and oligarchy** and rests on a strong **middle class**, which makes it **stable** — the middle moderates between rich and poor, so neither extreme captures the state.
- Its **three principles** (the lecture's framing):
  - **Phronesis over sophia** — good rule needs **practical wisdom from experience**, not abstract wisdom alone (Aristotle's implicit critique of Plato's philosopher-king).
  - **Taking turns** → **accountability** — citizens rule *and are ruled* in turn.
  - **Everyone shares in lawmaking** → **legitimacy**.
- **Vs Plato:** Plato — "*which men are most able to govern?*" → rule by the knowing few (**sophia**). Aristotle — "*what makes a good ruler?*" → **shared, accountable** rule by the many (**phronesis**). **Politeia is Aristotle's real-world answer to "who should rule."**
- **Terminology watch:** *politeia* also means "**constitution**" in general (and gives us the word "politics") — here it names the *specific* good form of majority rule (the just counterpart of **democracy**, which for

Aristotle is the *corrupt* form).

## Rome — republic, law & clientelism

**Core:** Rome adds the **mixed constitution** and the **rule of law** — but on a **weak civil state** riddled with **clientelism**.

- **Polybius & Cicero:** Republican Rome was best because it **mixed** monarchy (two **consuls**), aristocracy (the **Senate**) and democracy (the **People's Assembly** / **tribunes**).
- **Rule of law:** Cicero brings **Natural Law** ("the true law of reason according to Nature") to Rome; expressed in **ius gentium** (law of peoples) & **ius civile** (law of citizens). Roman law = codified **protection of life & property** from government abuse; introduces **contracts & corporations**. But a **weak state** (no police, no public prosecutor — only the wealthy could bring a case) → power rested on the **strongest army** and on **clientelism** (patron–client bonds of power, dependency & obligation — *not* rights).
- Arc: kingdom (753 BC) → **Republic (509–49 BC)** → Caesar assassinated (44 BC) → **Augustus**, first emperor (27 BC); **Caracalla (AD 212)** grants citizenship to all free men.

## From Stoicism to Christianity

**Core:** the **Stoics** universalise **natural law** — everyone is born with equal **logos** (reason) — the first hint that **all are in principle equal**, later carried into Christianity.

- **Stoicism:** equal *logos* → slavery & the suppression of women are *unnatural*; **Seneca:** a citizen may be legally free yet morally a slave — seek **spiritual** freedom. Transferred to Christianity: freedom = **submission to faith**; all equal **in God's eyes** (created in His image).
- **Augustine (354–430):** **two states** (God's and Man's); **Natural Law** = Divine Law; true freedom only in Paradise; slavery = God's punishment for sin.
- **Aquinas (1224–74):** peace & God's **Cosmopolis**; man submits to divine authority (God & pope); a **moral economy**.

## Ancient economic thinking

**Core:** economics = **household (oikos)** management on land & slavery; **trade is inferior/"unnatural,"** and **usury** (money-lending) is immoral.

- **Xenophon's Oikonomikos:** wealth from good **estate management**. Exchange was **hierarchical**, only partly market-based; distribution via **gifts, plunder, tribute, prizes, local markets**.
- **Just prices vs artificial prices;** money-lending = **usury** = immoral. Ideal: "*rich enough to pursue virtue*" (Greeks: no excess; Romans: wealth = responsibility). (*This is where Galbraith's & Backhouse's "ancient world" economics begins.*)

## Greek & Roman terms we still use

- **Greek:** *politeia* (affairs of the city) → **politics** · *monos+archo* → **monarchy** · *aristos+kratos* → **aristocracy** · *demos+kratos* → **democracy** · *tyrannos* → **tyranny** · *oikos+nemein* (household + manage) → **economy**.

- **Latin:** *res publica* → **republic** · *imperium* → **empire** · *dictator* → **dictatorship** · *civitas* → **citizen/city** · *populus* → **people/populism** · **constitution** (how things are constituted).

## Take-away — ancient political philosophy

- It debated natural law vs the laws of the state; reflected on justice, rule of law, and forms of constitution/government; and weighed duty to the family (*oikos*) against duty to the polis and religion → the enduring question of **individual freedom vs. obligation to society**.

## Reeve — 'Plato'

In: David Boucher & Paul Kelly (eds), *Political Thinkers* (2003), **ch. 4**, by **C.D.C. Reeve** (pp. 55–72). Main text: Plato, *Republic*.

### Chapter résumé

An analytic tour of Plato's political philosophy, built almost entirely on the **Republic**. Reeve shows how Plato's **metaphysics** (the Theory of **Forms**, crowned by the **Form of the Good**) grounds his **politics**: since only the philosopher *knows* the Good, only the philosopher-king should rule. He walks through the ideal city (kallipolis): its origin in the division of labour, its tripartite structure mirroring the tripartite soul, and **justice** as everyone "doing their own" job. He then confronts the notorious features — the **noble lie**, abolition of family and property for the guardians, equality of women, eugenics, exposure of infants, slavery, and **censorship of art** — before ending on the clash with modern **liberal freedom**: Plato restricts liberty because he aims at citizens' *real* good, which (he thinks) requires being ruled by knowledge.

★ **The heart of the chapter:** Plato's politics falls straight out of his **metaphysics** — because only the philosopher *knows* the Form of the Good, only the **philosopher-king** should rule; and **justice = each class doing its own job** in the kallipolis.

### Key concepts / "modes" to use

- **Theory of Forms & the Form of the Good** (the "good-itself") — the metaphysical foundation.
- Philosopher-king — rule belongs to those who *know* the Good.
- Tripartite soul / city: appetitive → producers (money-lovers); spirited → guardians/auxiliaries (honour-lovers); rational → rulers (wisdom-lovers).
- **Justice = specialization** ("doing one's own work"), the principle that structures the whole city.
- **Sun / Line / Cave** analogies — how we know the Good.
- **The three cities**: City-1 (healthy/"true"), City-2 (luxurious/"feverish"), City-3 (purified = kallipolis).
- **Genuine lie vs verbal lie** (the "noble lie" / myth of the metals).

## Section-by-section main points

### Biography & framing

- Plato c. 429–347 BC, from a leading aristocratic Athenian family (related to Solon; brothers **Glaucon & Adeimantus** appear in the *Republic*). Founded the **Academy**. The **execution of Socrates (399 BC)** turned him away from a political career toward philosophy.
- **Key texts:** the *Republic* is central; Plato's dialogues are grouped into four chronological sets (early/Socratic → late).

### An overview of the *Republic*

- **Book 1** — Thrasymachus: "justice is the **interest of the stronger**." Socrates' refutation (*elenchus*) is inadequate; **Glaucon & Adeimantus** renew the challenge, demanding justice be shown **intrinsically** (not just instrumentally) good.
- Plato's answer: the just city ruled by **philosopher-kings** who possess **knowledge of the Form of the Good** (not mere opinion). Political rule should go to those *best fitted by knowledge*.
- The city's three classes are produced by **eugenics + the "noble lie"**. Guardians live under a form of **communism** (no private property or family) so that no private interest competes with the city's good. **Censorship** shapes character.
- **Justice** = each person/class performing the **one social role** they are naturally best fitted for.

### Forms and the good-itself

- Discussion of poetry (Books 2–3) leads to **Forms** as eternal **patterns/blueprints** (of virtues, of a good city).
- **Sun analogy:** the **Good** is to the intelligible realm what the sun is to the visible — the source both of things' **being** and of their **knowability**. Rational order = goodness = intelligibility.
- Knowing the **good-itself** is what lets the philosopher make the kallipolis genuinely good (it is the "cause" of a thing's good order).

### The structure of the *kallipolis*

- The ideal city is developed in three stages: **City-1** (the healthy "true" city), **City-2** (the luxurious/"feverish" city, once appetites expand), **City-3** (the purified city = kallipolis).
- The kallipolis is a **real possibility**, not an idle utopia — but only if **philosopher-kings** rule.

### Specialization

- **Principle of specialization / unique-aptitude doctrine:** each does the single job their nature suits them for. This is the foundation of **justice**.
- Reeve notes Plato really relies on **quasi-specialization** — three broad natural types (money-lovers, honour-lovers, wisdom-lovers), not a unique craft per person.



## | The lies of the rulers

- **Genuine ("true") lie** = a false belief in the soul about the most important things — *always* bad.
- **Verbal lie** = words that mislead — can be a useful "**medicine**," legitimately used by rulers (like the myth of the metals) for the city's good.
- Only the **philosopher-kings**, who *know* the good, are entitled to deploy such lies.

## | Private life and private property

- Guardians have **no private property and no private family** — a "communism" of the ruling classes — to remove competing private interests.
- **Women guardians** are trained and rule alongside men: the principle of specialization applies to individuals regardless of sex (though child-bearing is noted). Plato is **not a feminist**, but the implication is radical for its time.
- Reproduction managed by a rigged lottery / community of wives & children (a eugenics programme).

## | Invalids, infants, slaves

- **Medicine** should restore people to a worthwhile life, **not prolong** lives too ill to function; deformed **infants** are (controversially) exposed — Reeve flags this as debated.
- **Slavery**: the kallipolis probably contains slaves (barbarian, not Greek), but Plato's position is ambiguous and less central than Aristotle's.

## | Censorship of the arts

- Poetry and art are **censored** because they misrepresent gods and virtue, feed the **appetitive** (not rational) part of the soul, and weaken character. Art must **serve education**. This is Plato's famous quarrel with poetry.

## | Freedom and autonomy

- Modern **liberal** objection: the kallipolis crushes individual freedom.
- Reeve's reconstruction of Plato's reply: distinguish a person's **real interests** (what truly fulfils their nature → real happiness) from mere **desires**. Liberal **instrumental/negative freedom** (satisfy whatever desires you happen to have) may not serve real interests; **deliberative freedom** requires the right education and knowledge.
- Because the kallipolis aims at citizens' **real good**, Plato claims it delivers *more* real freedom (fulfilment) even while restricting license. Liberal **neutrality among conceptions of the good** is itself a contestable value.

## Cases & examples

Plato argues through **thought-experiments and images**, not country cases — but you're expected to know these cold, so here's *what each one actually says*.

- **Thrasymachus's challenge (Book 1).** The sophist Thrasymachus asserts that "**justice is the interest of the stronger**" — rulers simply make laws that serve themselves and call it "just." Socrates' on-the-spot refutation (the *elenchus*) is weak, so **Glaucon and Adeimantus** re-pose the challenge: show that justice is good **in itself**, not just for its rewards. → *Sets up the entire argument of the Republic* — everything after is Plato's answer.
- **The three cities.** Plato builds the ideal city in stages: **City-1**, the "healthy"/"true" city of simple needs; **City-2**, the "luxurious"/"feverish" city once appetites and luxuries balloon (now it needs a guardian/soldier class); and **City-3**, the **purified** city — the kallipolis — once reason (the philosopher-kings) governs the whole. → *Shows the kallipolis is reached by purifying a realistic city, not conjured from nothing.*
- **The Sun analogy.** Just as the sun both lets us **see** objects and makes them **grow**, the **Form of the Good** makes the other Forms both **knowable** and gives them their very **being**. → *Illustrates why the Good is the highest object of knowledge and the source of the city's goodness — the metaphysical root of rule by philosophers.*
- **The Allegory of the Cave.** Prisoners chained facing a wall take flickering **shadows** for reality; one is freed, dazzled by the sunlight, and slowly comes to see real things and finally the sun itself. → *Illustrates education as turning the soul from appearances toward the Good — and why the enlightened philosopher must (reluctantly) go back down to rule.*
- **The myth of the metals (the noble lie).** Citizens are told a "needful" story: that god mixed **gold** into the rulers, **silver** into the auxiliaries, and **bronze/iron** into the producers at birth. → *Illustrates the "lies of the rulers" — a verbal lie used to legitimate the class structure and secure loyalty to the city.*
- **The rigged marriage lottery.** Guardian reproduction is arranged by a lottery that is secretly **fixed** so the "best" breed with the "best," while the couples believe the pairing was pure chance. → *Illustrates Plato's eugenics and the abolition of the private family among the guardians.*

## Key terms

| Term                           | Meaning                                                                   |
|--------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Form / Theory of Forms         | Eternal, intelligible patterns; the true objects of knowledge             |
| Form of the Good (good-itself) | Highest Form; source of being & knowability (Sun analogy)                 |
| Philosopher-king               | Ruler who <i>knows</i> the Good; only they should rule                    |
| Tripartite soul                | Rational / spirited / appetitive parts                                    |
| Three classes                  | Rulers (wisdom) / guardians-auxiliaries (honour) / producers (money)      |
| Justice                        | Each part/class doing its own proper work (specialization)                |
| Kallipolis                     | Plato's ideal ("beautiful") city                                          |
| Noble lie / myth of the metals | Verbal lie used to legitimate the class structure                         |
| Genuine vs verbal lie          | False belief in the soul (always bad) vs misleading words (can be useful) |
| Real interests vs desires      | What truly fulfils us vs what we happen to want                           |



## Exam pointers

- Be able to trace the **metaphysics → politics** move: Form of the Good → philosopher-king → kallipolis.
- Know the **soul ↔ city** parallel and **justice = specialization** codd.
- Distinguish genuine vs verbal lie and explain why the noble lie is (for Plato) permissible.
- Be ready to state Plato's **anti-liberal** account of freedom (real interests vs desires).

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## McClelland — Aristotle

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**Book:** J.S. McClelland, *A History of Western Political Thought* (1996), pp. 52–68 (chapter section "Aristotle and the Science of Politics", in Part "The Greeks").

### Chapter résumé

McClelland presents Aristotle as the **empirical, scientific** counterpart to Plato. After a biographical sketch (the Macedonian connection, the Lyceum), he tackles the textual "**problem**" — the *Politics* is a jumbled, probably lecture-derived text (Jaeger's developmental thesis). His central claim: Aristotle's political science is **empirical in the way his biology is** — it studies the *polis* as a natural organism, takes **received opinion** seriously, and asks what **nature intends**. The reading then maps the eight books of the *Politics*, and develops two big Aristotelian doctrines: the **naturalness of rulership** (natural hierarchies, the household, slavery) and the **naturalness of the polis** (man as a *political animal*, the *polis* as the *telos* of human community, and the classification of constitutions).

★ **The heart of the chapter:** Aristotle studies politics **empirically, like biology** — the **polis exists by nature** (man is a political animal), and regimes are judged **good vs. corrupt** by whether they serve the **common interest** (the six-fold classification of constitutions).

### Key concepts / "modes" to use

- **Teleology** — everything has an *end* (*telos*); "nature does nothing in vain."
- **Empirical method** — study politics like biology; give **received opinion** (*endoxa*) a hearing.
- **Naturalness of the polis** — man is by nature a **political animal**; the *polis* exists by nature and is **prior** to the individual.
- **Natural rulership** — some rule / some are ruled by nature (master–slave, husband–wife, parent–child).
- **Classification of constitutions** — 3 good vs 3 corrupt forms.
- **Phronesis** (practical wisdom) vs **sophia** (theoretical wisdom); rule of law vs rule of men.

## Section-by-section main points

### Biography

- Born **384 BC in Stageira** (Macedonian Thrace); father was court physician to the Macedonian king. Studied ~20 years at **Plato's Academy**. Tutored the young **Alexander the Great**. Founded his own school, the **Lyceum** (covered walk = *peripatos* → "**Peripatetics**"), with a vast curriculum — "the first real university." Left Athens twice amid **anti-Macedonian** feeling; died at **Chalcis, 322 BC**.

### The Problem of Aristotle's *Politics*

- Aristotle was Plato's pupil but **broke away**; the *Politics* is famously **disorganised** — possibly a compilation of **lecture notes**.
- **Jaeger's thesis**: distinguish the "**Original Politics**" (Books 2, 3, 7, 8 — Platonic, about the ideal/best state) from the truly "**Aristotelian Politics**" (Books 4, 5, 6 — empirical), with **Book 1** written last as a general introduction.
- Aristotle's political science is **empirical like his biology**: study how politics actually works, and give **common/received opinion** ("even the mistakes of the past can be instructive") a sympathetic hearing.
- "**Nature does nothing without a purpose**." Political science is **useful**: identify what nature *intends* and amend what frustrates it — Aristotle is **not** merely the theorist of the second-best.

### A Map of the *Politics*

- **Book 1** — the *polis* exists by nature (against the Sophist "convention only" view); defence of natural **slavery**; the household & the acquisition of wealth (original meaning of "**economics**"); natural rule based on possession of **reason**.
- **Book 2** — ideal communities; critique of **Plato's Republic** (community of wives/children, property); property best held **privately but used in common**.
- **Book 3** — definitions: *What is the polis?* = its **constitution**; *What is a citizen?* (one who shares in office/justice); the **classification of constitutions** — three **good** forms (**monarchy, aristocracy, politeia**) and their **corrupt** counterparts (**tyranny, oligarchy, democracy**); on kingship.
- **Books 4, 5, 6** — the **empirical heart**: the **morphology and pathology** of states; five key questions (how many kinds of constitution; which is best in normal circumstances; which suits which population; how to organise them; **how constitutions are preserved and destroyed**). **Book 5** = political **pathology and preventive medicine** (causes of revolution; how regimes are preserved — obedience to law).
- **Books 7, 8** — "Platonic": Aristotle on the **best state** (ideal population size, territory, and **education**).

### The Naturalness of Rulership

- Aristotle's **teleological biology** drives the politics. Some things naturally **rule**, others are naturally **ruled**; the natural pairs are **master–slave, husband–wife, father–children**, combining into the **household**, then village, then *polis*.

- **Ends:** the *polis* is the *end* toward which lesser communities develop — "prior" in the sense of **completion**, not in time (the acorn/oak analogy).
- **Slavery:** the "natural slave" lacks the **deliberative/directive faculty** (reason); the master's intelligence directs him, as mind directs body. But Aristotle is **uneasy/embarrassed** — he concedes many actual slaves are enslaved by mere **convention/conquest** (the Sophist objection), so his defence is **weak** and applies only to a hypothetical "natural" slave.
- **Kingship** = rule of **intelligence over desire**, like soul over body; legitimate if the king rules in the interest of all.

## | The Naturalness of the *Polis*

- **Phronesis** (practical wisdom for contingent human affairs) is distinct from **sophia** (theoretical wisdom); politics needs *phronesis*.
- The *polis* **exists by nature** as the *telos* of household → village → *polis*; **man is by nature a political animal**; the *polis* is **prior to the individual** (only in it can we live the "good life," not mere life).
- **Rule of law vs rule of men:** law should be supreme **in general**, with men deciding **particular** cases law can't foresee.
- Constitutions judged by whether rulers serve the **common interest** (good) or their **own** (corrupt); Aristotle allows that the **"many," collectively**, may be wiser than the few.

**Notes on Sources** (p. 68) — reading recommendations (Penguin *Politics*; Jaeger; Barker; Ross; MacIntyre's *After Virtue*).

## Cases & examples

Aristotle reasons from **analogies and a classification scheme** — know these in semi-depth.

- **The six-fold classification of constitutions.** Aristotle sorts every regime along two axes — *who rules* (one / few / many) × *in whose interest* (the **common good** = correct; the **rulers' own** = corrupt): **monarchy** → **tyranny** (one), **aristocracy** → **oligarchy** (few), **polity** (*politeia*) → **democracy** (many). → *The core exam item:* a regime is "good" when it serves the common interest, "corrupt" when rulers serve themselves; note "democracy" is the *corrupt* form of majority rule (its good form is *politeia*).
- **The acorn and the oak (teleology).** As an acorn's *end* (*telos*) is to become an oak, the *end* of human association is the **polis**. So the polis is "prior" to the household and village not in *time* but as their **completion**. → *Illustrates why the polis is "natural" and why studying it means asking what it is for.*
- **Household → village → polis.** The natural pairs (**master–slave, husband–wife, parent–child**) form the **household** (*oikos*); households cluster into the **village**; villages combine into the self-sufficient **polis**, where the "good life" — not mere survival — first becomes possible. → *Illustrates the naturalness of the polis and the claim that man is by nature a political animal.*
- **The natural slave.** Aristotle claims some people are "slaves by nature": lacking the **deliberative faculty**, they are rightly directed by a master's reason, as the body is by the mind. But he immediately concedes that many *actual* slaves were enslaved only by **conquest or convention** (the Sophist objection) — so his own defence comes out **uneasy and weak**. → *Illustrates the clash between his tidy teleology and messy observed reality.*

## Key terms

| Term                                       | Meaning                                                            |
|--------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Telos / teleology                          | The natural <i>end</i> or purpose of a thing                       |
| Political animal ( <i>zoon politikon</i> ) | Humans are by nature made to live in a <i>polis</i>                |
| Polis prior to the individual              | The whole (city) is prior in nature to its parts                   |
| Natural slave                              | One lacking the deliberative faculty (Aristotle's uneasy doctrine) |
| Household ( <i>oikos</i> )                 | Basic natural unit; root of "economics"                            |
| Constitution ( <i>politeia</i> )           | The arrangement of offices; defines the <i>polis</i>               |
| Good vs corrupt constitutions              | Monarchy/aristocracy/polity vs tyranny/oligarchy/democracy         |
| Phronesis / sophia                         | Practical wisdom / theoretical wisdom                              |
| Rule of law                                | Law supreme in general; men decide particular cases                |

## Exam pointers

- Frame Aristotle as **empirical/naturalist** vs Plato's **idealist** — the key contrast of the week.
- Reproduce the six-fold classification of constitutions (3 good / 3 corrupt) and the good-vs-corrupt test (common vs self-interest).
- Explain **man as political animal** + polis prior to the individual via the *telos* argument.
- Be able to state *and criticise* Aristotle's natural slavery argument (the convention/conquest objection).

## Galbraith — 'A Look at the Landscape'

**Book:** John Kenneth Galbraith, *A History of Economics: The Past as the Present* (1987), **ch. I**, pp. 1–8.

## Chapter résumé

Galbraith's opening chapter is a **manifesto for reading economics historically**. His central claim: **economic ideas are always a product of their own time and place**, so they can't be understood apart from the world they interpret — and as that world changes, ideas must **transform or lose relevance**. He explains what his history will and won't do (central ideas over exhaustive detail; heavy focus on the last century's money/banking/trade debates), attacks the vested interest that makes economics resist change, and names the discipline's **two central subjects**: the theory of value (prices) and the theory of distribution (wages, interest, profit, rent). He notes a historical shift of emphasis from **value/prices** toward **distribution** and the aggregate performance of the economy (employment, growth). Finally he defends writing a **critical** (not detached) history and warns against economic **forecasting**.

★ **The heart of the chapter: economic ideas are always a product of their own time and place** — to understand economics you must read its ideas against the world that produced them; when the world changes, the ideas must change too.

## Key concepts / "modes" to use

- **History-of-ideas approach** — you cannot understand economics without its history.
- **Ideas as products of time & place** — the book's organising thesis.
- **Theory of value (prices) vs theory of distribution (wages/interest/profit/rent)** — the two great subjects.
- **Shift from scarcity/value to affluence/distribution/aggregate** — how the subject's centre of gravity moved.
- **Vested interest & resistance to change** — why comfortable ideas persist.
- **Limits of forecasting** — economists can't reliably predict.

## Section-by-section main points

### Why the history matters

- "There can be no understanding of economics without an awareness of its history." Economic ideas' authors owe a huge debt to predecessors; the "controlling ideas" are often lost in the mass of writing.
- **Core thesis:** *economic ideas are always and intimately a product of their own time and place; they cannot be seen apart from the world they interpret.* As the world changes, ideas are **transformed** — or become irrelevant.

### What this history will do

- Not merely a history of ideas: he ties ideas to the **events that shaped them**, and emphasises **central ideas** over exhaustive detail — with special attention to the **last century** (intense debate over **banking, money, monetary policy, international trade, tariffs**).
- Change in economics is **resisted** — those who benefit from the *status quo* resist change; established ideas persist because they serve a **vested interest**.
- Two great organising reference points: **Adam Smith** and the modern era (Ricardo, the Industrial Revolution, **Keynes**, the Great Depression). (*In the book, Part I = "before Adam," Ch. II = "After Adam."*)

### The two central subjects of economics

- **Theory of value** — what determines **prices** (and the value of goods).
- **Theory of distribution** — how the proceeds are shared: **wages, interest, profit, rent** (returns to labour, capital, land).
- Historically, **prices/value** were the very centre of the subject (esp. 18th c.). In modern, more affluent times, **distribution of income** and the **aggregate performance** of the economy — employment, growth, fluctuations, depressions — have become the more urgent, "most sensitive" questions.

- Beyond value & distribution lie the questions of **institutions** (banks, firms, government) and the larger **political and social framework** (capitalism, the welfare state, socialism/communism) — and when these change, economics undergoes "rather major change."

## On method and forecasting

- The history should be told in **clear, agreeable English**, and can legitimately be written for **enjoyment** as well as instruction.
- Galbraith writes a **critical** history (he'll exercise judgment, not feign detachment) — economics is a "theater of avowed and strongly expressed argument."
- **Beware forecasting**: economists cannot reliably predict; the future is unknowable. (Keynes: "*In the long run we are all dead.*") A forecaster who truly *knew* the future would use the knowledge himself, not sell it.
- **Marshall's definition** (quoted): "Political Economy or Economics... is a study of mankind in the ordinary business of life."

## Key terms

| Term                             | Meaning                                                 |
|----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| History of economic ideas        | Studying economics through the development of its ideas |
| Ideas as product of time & place | Galbraith's central thesis                              |
| Theory of value                  | What determines prices / the value of goods             |
| Theory of distribution           | How income is shared: wages, interest, profit, rent     |
| Aggregate performance            | Economy-wide employment, growth, fluctuations           |
| Vested interest                  | Why comfortable/status-quo ideas resist change          |
| Critical history                 | History written with judgment, not feigned detachment   |

## Exam pointers

- Nail Galbraith's **thesis** in one line: *economic ideas are products of their time and place; when the world changes, ideas must change too.*
- Know the **value vs distribution** distinction — and the historical **shift** toward distribution and aggregate performance.
- Use the **forecasting** warning (Keynes) and the **vested-interest** point as ready critiques.

## Bridge across the week

Plato and Aristotle set the **normative-ideal** vs **empirical-natural** poles of political thought; Galbraith adds the meta-lesson that **all** such ideas — political and economic alike — must be read against the world that produced them. Aristotle's own "economics" (household management, Book 1 of the *Politics*) is a nice link to Galbraith's story of where economic thought *begins*.



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## ★ Reading questions — worked answers

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Study answers to Module 1's reading questions (Reeve on **Plato** · McClelland on **Aristotle** · Galbraith).  
Each: a one-line **Answer**, then the depth for Plato and Aristotle.

### 1 · What is the best city/state — for Plato and Aristotle? Why?

**Answer: Plato** — the kallipolis, *one* ideal city ordered by knowledge of the Good. **Aristotle** — *it depends*: an ideal polis of the "good life," but the best **achievable** is the politeia (a mixed, middle-class constitution).

- **Plato (Reeve)**: the best city is the kallipolis — the purified "City-3" ruled by **philosopher-kings** who know the Form of the Good. It is best because it is ordered by **knowledge, not opinion**: the rational element rules, each class does the one job its nature fits (justice = specialization), and the city mirrors the well-ordered soul. It's a *single* ideal, reachable only by reason.
- **Aristotle (McClelland)**: refuses one blueprint. He separates the **ideal** state (*Politics* Books 7–8 — the "good life," right size/territory, citizens with leisure for virtue) from the **best practicable** — the politeia ("polity"), a "**mixed**" / **middle-class constitution**, because it is the most **stable** (the middle moderates between rich and poor). A regime is *good* when it rules in the **common interest**, and the **many collectively** may be wiser than the few.
- **Why they differ**: Plato the **idealist** derives the best city from the **Forms**; Aristotle the **empiricist** makes "best" plural and fitted to circumstances, and **criticises Plato's *Republic*** (Book 2) for abolishing family/property — which he says destroys natural affection and the household.

### 2 · Who should rule? Why?

**Answer: Plato** — the **philosopher-kings** (those who *know* the Good). **Aristotle** — whoever rules **in the common interest**, ideally the **virtuous**, but checked by the rule of law and often the **middle/many**.

- **Plato**: rule goes to those **best fitted by knowledge** — the **philosopher-kings**. Only knowledge of the Good (not opinion) can order the city rightly, just as **reason** should rule the soul. They rule **reluctantly** (they'd rather contemplate but must "return to the Cave") and **in the interest of all**.
- **Aristotle**: on "should **man or law** be supreme?" → **law supreme in general**, men deciding the particular cases law can't foresee. The **good** constitutions (monarchy, aristocracy, politeia) rule for the **common interest**; their corrupt twins (tyranny, oligarchy, democracy) rule for the rulers. A truly **kingly man** of outstanding virtue may rule — but only if for all; otherwise the **collective wisdom of the many** and the middle class are safer.
- **Contrast**: Plato = rule by the **one/few who know**; Aristotle = rule by the **virtuous serving the common good, constrained by law**.

### 3 · How are freedom and privacy protected in the kallipolis?

**Answer**: In the modern liberal sense they mostly **aren't** — privacy is *abolished* for the guardians and individual license is heavily restricted. Plato's defence: **true freedom = living by your *real interests***

under the rule of knowledge, and private property/family are competing interests that corrupt the rulers.

- **Privacy is removed, deliberately:** guardians have no private property and no private family (a "communism" of the rulers), plus a rigged marriage lottery, controlled education, and censorship of the arts — all to delete competing private interests so nothing rivals the good of the city.
- **Individual freedom is restricted, not protected:** the noble lie, fixed class roles and censorship constrain what citizens may do, believe and hear.
- **Plato's reply (Reeve, "Freedom and autonomy"):** distinguish **real interests** (what truly fulfils your nature → real happiness) from mere **desires**. Liberal *negative* freedom (do whatever you want) may not serve your real interests; **deliberative freedom** needs knowledge and the right education. So the kallipolis claims to deliver *more* **real** freedom — each person fulfilling their nature — precisely by restricting **license**. Privacy is sacrificed for the **unity** of the city.
- **The lecture's phrasing (BAP):** "*Freedom is preserved, since everybody is made equal and secure by the state and enabled to realize his/her potentials*" — i.e. freedom as **fulfilment**, not license (the same move as Reeve's real-interests defence).
- **Exam framing:** don't answer "freedom is protected." Say: *the kallipolis subordinates privacy and license to the city's unity and the citizens' real good; Plato redefines freedom as fulfilment under the rule of knowledge* — the anti-liberal move.

#### 4 • What is honour? What is virtue?

*Answer (the lecture's civic definitions — BAP):* **Honour** = the ability & willingness to **defend the city/country against its enemies**. **Virtue** = a sense of **obligation & responsibility toward society**, to keep it from falling apart. Together: **Honour + Virtue = protection against anarchy or conquest by others — and the way to stay in power.**

- **Deeper — Plato (the soul):** in the tripartite soul, the **spirited** part seeks **honour, victory, reputation** (its people = the **honour-lovers/guardians**; a city ruled by them = a *timocracy*). Plato's four cardinal virtues map onto the parts — **wisdom** (rulers), **courage** (guardians), **temperance** (agreement on who rules), and **justice = each part doing its own work**; virtue is grounded in **knowledge** of the Good.
- **Deeper — Aristotle (the good life):** the polis exists so citizens can live "the good life" (*eudaimonia*) — a life of **virtue** built by **habit** and guided by **phronesis**. Honour is sought as a *sign* of virtue, but virtue is the higher, **intrinsic** end.

#### 5 • What is idealism? What is materialism?

*Answer:* **Idealism** = reality is grounded in **ideas / forms / mind** (the intelligible is more real than the physical). **Materialism** = reality is grounded in **matter** (the physical/economic base is primary; ideas are derived). Plato is the classic **idealist**; the week's other pole leans **materialist/empirical**.

- **Idealism (Plato):** the truly real is the **Forms** — eternal intelligible patterns; the Form of the Good is the highest reality, and the physical world is a mere **shadow/copy** (the Cave). Knowledge is of Forms, not the changing senses — so rule belongs to those who *know* the Forms.

- **Materialism:** the **material/economic** world is primary; ideas and institutions are shaped by material conditions. The key political-economy example is **Marx's historical materialism** (the economic *base* determines the *superstructure* of ideas).
- **Aristotle sits between:** a **naturalist/empiricist** who studies the *actual* world (the polis as a natural organism, teleology in nature) — a counterweight to Platonic idealism, though not a strict materialist.
- **Galbraith tie-in:** his thesis that **economic ideas are products of their own time and place** is a *materialist* reading of ideas — fitting the week's **idealist (Plato) vs materialist/empirical (Aristotle, Marx, Galbraith)** contrast.
- **The lecture crystallises it (BAP): Ideas (Plato) vs Matter (Aristotle)** — as in **Raphael's School of Athens** (Plato points *up* to the eternal Forms; Aristotle gestures *down/out* toward the observed world).

## ★ Fun facts & memorable details

The sticky examples, witty asides and quotable lines from this week — great for essays, exam colour, or just remembering who's who.

### Aristotle trivia (McClelland is full of it)

- McClelland says Aristotle was "**a snappy dresser**" who "**affected an aristocratic lisp.**"
- The **Lyceum's** covered walk was the *peripatos* — which is exactly why Aristotle's followers are called the **Peripatetics** (the "walking-about" philosophers).
- Aristotle's kinsman **Callisthenes** went east with Alexander to write the campaign history and recite Homer whenever Alexander got drunk and thought he was **Achilles** — possibly planted as **Aristotle's spy**. He was later executed.
- **The banquet at Opis (324 BC):** Alexander reconciled Macedonians and Persians, married **10,000** of his veterans to Asian concubines, and pleaded for *omonoia* (concord between the races). McClelland calls it "*the supremely anti-Aristotelian moment*" — it dissolved the Greek/barbarian distinction Aristotle's reason had so carefully drawn.
- In Aristotle's scheme of kingship, McClelland dryly notes, "*there are no queens.*"
- The word "**economics**" comes from Greek *oikonomikos* — **household management** (*Politics* Book 1).
- The historian **Polybius** later coined "**ochlocracy**" (mob-rule) for Aristotle's corrupt form of "democracy."
- The *Politics* may literally be a **bundle of students' lecture notes** — which is why scholars agree "the book is a mess."

### Plato trivia

- Plato came from top-drawer Athenian aristocracy (related to **Solon**); his brothers **Glaucon and Adeimantus** are characters in the *Republic*.
- The **noble lie / myth of the metals:** citizens are told they were born with **gold, silver, or bronze** in their souls, to justify the class system.
- The ideal city runs a **rigged marriage lottery** (eugenics) and gives its guardians **no private property and no family** — a "communism" of the rulers.

- Plato would **expose deformed infants** and refuse to treat the incurably ill: medicine should restore people to a *worthwhile* life, not merely prolong it.
- Plato's three great images for knowing the Good: the **Sun**, the **Divided Line**, and the **Cave**.

#### Galbraith / economics

- Galbraith's one-line thesis: "*economic ideas are always and intimately a product of their own time and place.*"
- **Marshall's** still-quoted definition: economics is "*a study of mankind in the ordinary business of life.*"
- The **forecaster's paradox**: anyone who truly knew the economic future would quietly use the knowledge to get rich — not sell it in a newsletter. (Hence Keynes: "*In the long run we are all dead.*")
- Galbraith subtitled his book "**A Critical History**" — he refuses to pose as a detached, dispassionate scientist.

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## Module 2: Renaissance and Early-Modern Political Theory — from Cosmopolis to *Stato* to the Social Contract

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**Readings:** McClelland, *A History of Western Political Thought*, ch. 11 (Hobbes, pp. 191–228) · Grotius (Boisen, *Political Thinkers*-style chapter) **Focus:** Thomas Hobbes: *Leviathan and the social covenant* · Hugo Grotius *and the world system of states*.

**Theme of the module:** the long shift from the medieval **Cosmopolis** (one universal Christian moral-legal order — Module 1's Aquinas) to the modern world of **sovereign states**. Three moves: **Machiavelli** frees politics from morality and invents the autonomous *stato* → **Hobbes** gives that state a **contractual foundation** and a *science* of absolute **sovereignty** → **Grotius** builds the **world system of states** bound by **natural law** (the birth of international law).

★ **The heart of the module — each thinker in one idea** (keep these in view):

- **Machiavelli → the *stato*:** politics is its own domain, freed from ethics; built on a fixed, pessimistic view of human nature.
  - **Hobbes → the social covenant:** from a **state of nature** ("war of all against all") rational egoists **covenant with each other** to authorise an **absolute sovereign** (Leviathan) — anything less collapses back into war.
  - **Grotius → the world system of states:** a **natural law** of universal rights & duties (binding "even if God did not exist") governs sovereigns too — grounding property, the free sea, and a **just-war** international order.
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# McClelland — Hobbes: *Leviathan* and the Social Covenant

## Chapter résumé

McClelland reads Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651) as "*the first masterpiece of social-contract theory*" — yet a deeply **untypical** one: contract language was invented to justify *resistance*, but Hobbes turns it into an argument **for absolute government**, "driving a coach and four through all the libertarian conclusions." Written amid the **English Civil War**, it builds the state **geometrically** from a bleak view of human nature: from a state of nature ("war of every man against every man," life "solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short"), self-interested **rational egoists** reason their way to a **covenant** transferring their unlimited Right of Nature to a **Sovereign** who is *not himself a party* to the contract — and whose power must therefore be **absolute and undivided**, because anything less slides back into the state of nature.

★ **The heart:** Hobbes's chain — **state of nature** (war of all against all) → the **Right of Nature** is a curse everyone would shed → reason's **Law of Nature** says "seek peace" → so men **covenant with each other** to authorise one **Sovereign** (who stays outside the deal) → sovereignty must be **absolute & undivided**, or you're back in the war.

**The red thread.** Read the whole argument as a **geometry**: the *axiom* is man as a **rational egoist**; the *theorems* are the Laws of Nature, the Social Contract, and absolute Sovereignty. For any step ask: *how does self-interested fear drive it, and why does it force the conclusion that the sovereign must have everything?*

## Key concepts / "modes" to use

- State of nature — no government → "war of all against all."
- Right of Nature (a *permission*: unlimited liberty to preserve yourself) vs Law of Nature (a *command* of reason: seek peace).
- The social covenant — every man with every man; the sovereign is **beneficiary, not party**.
- **Sovereign / Leviathan** — the "mortal god"; **authorisation** ("what my agent does, I do"); **absolute & undivided**.
- Iniquity vs injury · sovereignty by institution vs acquisition · the efficiency constraint.

## Section-by-section main points

### The Machiavelli bridge — the autonomous *stato*

**Core:** Machiavelli supplies the ground Hobbes builds on — **politics as its own domain**, cut loose from morality and religion, resting on a fixed, pessimistic view of human nature.

- *The Prince*: no natural law, no scripture — Machiavelli simply "treats those assumptions as if they were not there." He wants **axioms that always work**, so he assumes men are "always very bad" ("heads he wins, tails he doesn't lose").
- **Fear over love** — "*treat everybody as a potential assassin*"; better to be feared than loved (Caligula's *Oderint dum metuant* — "let them hate, provided they fear"). **Virtù vs Fortuna**: skill meeting luck. (McClelland: "*Machiavelli anticipates Hobbes*.")



## ■ Hobbes's method — a geometry of man

**Core:** Hobbes builds politics like **Euclid** — from axioms about human nature to theorems — using the **new science** (matter in **motion**).

- **Materialist psychology:** humans are objects in **motion** (appetite/aversion); happiness is continual motion, not Aristotle's "rest." **Rational egoists** — Macpherson's "possessive individualists," "market-men" (the striking claim: "*a rising bourgeoisie requires an absolutist state*").

## ■ The state of nature — the war of all against all

**Core:** strip away government and you get **rough natural equality** → mutual fear → a **war of all against all** — a *disposition* to fight, not constant battle.

- **Equality:** "no man is so strong that he cannot be killed by another by stealth" → everyone is a threat. Three drivers: **competition** (gain), **diffidence** (fear/safety), **glory** (reputation). "*Part of man's nature is anti-social, while the other part can only be satisfied through social living.*"
- **War as a condition:** "*the nature of War consisteth not in actuall fighting, but in the known disposition thereto.*" The famous verdict: life is "**solitary, poore, nasty, brutish, and short.**"

## ■ Right of Nature vs Law of Nature

**Core:** the **Right** of Nature is a *permission* (do anything to survive); the **Law** of Nature is a *command* of reason (**seek peace**) — and reason tells you to *give up* the unlimited right.

- **Right of Nature** = unlimited liberty of self-preservation — but since *everyone* has it, it's "a millstone" you'd be wise to shed.
- **Law of Nature** (a "precept found out by reason" forbidding self-destruction): **1st** — "**seek peace, and follow it**"; **2nd** — **lay down your right to all things, as far as others will too**. In the state of nature these bind *in foro interno* (in conscience) but not *in foro externo* (in act) — no one dares go first.

## ■ ★ The social covenant — how you escape the state of nature

**Core:** you **can't make law by agreement** (who'd go first? who'd enforce it?) — so instead, **by agreement** choose a **law-giver**: everyone **covenants with everyone else** to transfer their Right of Nature to, and authorise, one **Sovereign**.

- **The key twist:** the covenant is of **every man with every man** — **NOT with the sovereign**. The sovereign is the **beneficiary, not a contracting party**, so *he makes no promise and can never "breach" the contract*. Everyone makes the leap into civil society **except the sovereign, who stays in the state of nature**.
- **Authorisation / representation:** the people **authorise everything the sovereign does** → "*what my agent does, I do... his will is my will.*" A people has a will **only through its representative** (the sovereign).
- **Institution vs Acquisition:** by **covenant** (the paradigm case) or by **conquest** (the ordinary historical case) — same result, because **fear doesn't invalidate a contract** ("all contracts are made through fear"; the man on a sinking ship "very willingly" throws his goods overboard).



## | The Sovereign / Leviathan — absolute, undivided, a "mortal god"

**Core:** the commonwealth is **Leviathan**, an "artificial man" / "**mortal god**"; because the sovereign is authorised by all, his power must be **absolute and undivided**.

- **Iniquity vs injury** (crucial): the sovereign, being a man, *can* act wickedly (**iniquity**) — but he can never do a subject an **injury** (an *unlawful* act), because he makes the law and the subject authorised him → "the supposed injury is something I have done to myself."
- Powers include: law, courts, war & peace ("the sword of justice is also the sword of war"), **censorship**, control of religion, appointments, honours — and it **repudiates all prior covenants, including any "covenant with God."**
- **The only right you keep = self-preservation:** "no man is obliged to walk unbound to the scaffold." Otherwise a rational man sheds his Right of Nature entirely.

## | Why absolutism — anything less collapses into war

**Core:** you **can't limit the sovereign by contract**, and you can't set up a judge over him without an **infinite regress** ("why stop at three?") that ends in "**the state of nature by another name.**"

- Stark disjunction: "*Either you choose to live under a Sovereign or you don't*" — divided/limited sovereignty just breeds rival sovereigns → **civil war**.
- **The real (non-legal) limit — the efficiency constraint:** the sovereign's *powers* are unlimited but his *power* (capacity to enforce) is not. Order holds **only while subjects fear the sovereign more than they fear each other**; when that reverses, "the rebellion has already happened internally."
- **International anarchy:** "*covenants without the sword are but breath*" — with no super-sovereign over states, there's no peace between them (McClelland: why the League of Nations/UN are "bound to fail"). (*This is exactly the gap Grotius tries to fill.*)
- (*Aside — the **political-obligation controversy**: does Hobbes give only **prudential** reasons to obey, or a real **moral** duty? If the Laws of Nature are genuinely **God's commands**, obligation is moral; if "mere dictates of prudence," you obey only when watched.*)

## Cases & examples

- **English Civil War (1642–51):** each attribute of sovereignty maps onto a live dispute — control of the **army/militia** (the 1642 trigger), **religion**, the **Common Law** "ancient constitution," the sale of honours. *Leviathan* was double-edged: usable by Charles I, Cromwell, and Charles II.
- **The Norman Conquest:** Hobbes implies William was "a true Sovereign by the free consent of the defeated English" at Hastings — demolishing the Whig "Norman Yoke" story (sovereignty by acquisition).
- **Grimmelshausen's *Simplicissimus* / the Thirty Years War** — the real-world picture of the state of nature (many sovereigns fighting for mastery).

## Key terms

| Term                               | Meaning                                                                   |
|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| State of nature                    | Life without government → "war of all against all"                        |
| Right of Nature                    | <i>Permission</i> : unlimited liberty to preserve yourself                |
| Law of Nature                      | <i>Command</i> of reason; <b>1st = seek peace</b>                         |
| Social covenant                    | Every man with every man authorises a sovereign                           |
| Sovereign as beneficiary not party | Why the sovereign can't "breach" the contract                             |
| Leviathan / "mortal god"           | The commonwealth as an artificial person                                  |
| Authorisation                      | "What my agent does, I do" — a people wills only via its sovereign        |
| Iniquity vs injury                 | Wickedness (possible) vs an <i>unlawful</i> act (impossible to a subject) |
| Institution vs acquisition         | Sovereignty by covenant vs by conquest                                    |
| Efficiency constraint              | Order lasts only while subjects fear the sovereign most                   |

## Exam pointers

- Run Hobbes's chain cold: state of nature → right vs law of nature → **the covenant of every man with every man** → absolute sovereign.
- Nail *why* the sovereign is **beneficiary, not party**, and what follows (no breach, no right of resistance beyond self-preservation).
- Explain the iniquity vs injury distinction and the **regress argument** for why sovereignty can't be divided.
- Use "*covenants without the sword are but breath*" to link Hobbes to the **international** problem Grotius addresses.

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## Grotius — Natural Law and the World System of States

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### Chapter résumé

**Hugo Grotius (1583–1645)**, Dutch jurist, aimed to "*formulate a set of universal rights and duties that would secure peace by constraining states in their internal and external relations.*" Amid the confessional chaos of the Thirty Years War he **rehabilitated natural law** on a **minimal, universal** basis everyone could accept, and applied it to the relations *between* sovereigns — earning him the title "**father of modern international law.**" His key move: natural law's obligatory force holds "**even if God did not exist**" (*etsi Deus non daretur*); from human **natural rights** (self-preservation, and the derived rights of **property** and **punishment**) he builds an order of sovereign states bound by a **law of nations** and a theory of **just war**. Unlike Hobbes, Grotius holds humans are **naturally sociable**.

★ **The heart:** there is a **universal natural law** — knowable by reason, binding even "if God did not exist" — that gives individuals **natural rights** (self-preservation → property → punishment) and applies **equally to states**. That's the foundation of the **world system of states**: free seas, property from occupation, and a **just-war** order in which even war is subject to law.

**The red thread.** Grotius scales **one idea** — **universal natural law/rights** — **up from individuals to states**. For each topic ask: *what does natural law permit or require here, and how does that constrain sovereigns?* Keep contrasting with **Hobbes**: same self-preservation start, but Grotius's humans are **sociable**, his natural law is genuinely **obligatory**, and his sovereign *can* be bound.

## Key concepts / "modes" to use

- Natural law — universal, immutable principles; known **a priori** (right reason) & **a posteriori** (agreement of nations); source = God, content = human nature.
- The "impious hypothesis" (*etsi Deus non daretur*) — natural law binds even if God did not exist.
- **Natural rights** (subjective — a *power* one "has"): self-defence & self-preservation → **property & punishment**.
- Mare Liberum — the free sea as a state of nature (grounds free navigation & trade).
- Appetitus societatis — humans are **naturally sociable** (vs Hobbes).
- The world system of states + just war (four just causes) + the right to punish.

## Section-by-section main points

### | Natural law — secularised and universal

**Core:** natural law = **universal, immutable principles we must act in conformity with**, knowable by **right reason** — a *minimal* moral basis everyone could accept "despite profound confessional strife."

- Content known **a priori** (by reason, from our rational & social nature) *and* **a posteriori** (the laws "to which all civilized nations subject" — "a universal effect requires a universal cause"). Dual foundation: **right reason AND God**, each able to carry the obligation.

### | ★ The "impious hypothesis" — *etsi Deus non daretur*

**Core:** the famous line — natural law "*would take place, though we should even grant... that there is no God.*" Its obligatory force seems **independent of God's existence**.

- **But note the qualification:** the *very next sentence* names God as Creator — so it's *not* atheism. Boisen's reading: a **deliberately vague** device to secure natural law's universality **across confessions**, not a denial of God. **Source of law = God; contents = human nature.** (*This is the move that starts to secularise natural law — hugely influential.*)

### | Natural rights — the *suum*, and rights as a power

**Core:** rights are **derived from facts about human nature** (chiefly sociability); a **subjective right** is "*something the individual possesses*" — a **power (potestas) over oneself** (liberty) or a claim over

others/things. Grotius is "the first to give a systematic account of **subjective** natural rights."

- Man is by nature **free and sui iuris** (subject to no one); the starting point is the **suum** (what is one's own). **Two primary rights:** self-defence & self-preservation → **two secondary claim-rights:** property and punishment.
- **Rights are limited by a duty** not to injure others: "*the very nature of injustice consists in nothing else but the violation of another's rights.*"

## | The Free Sea (*Mare Liberum*) — the sea as a state of nature

**Core:** the sea can't be owned — it's "by nature open to all"; the high seas function like a state of nature, grounding a natural right to **free navigation and trade**.

- Land can be parcelled into property (via occupation + agreement); the sea **cannot be occupied**, so it stays common. (*Written to justify the Dutch (VOC) breaking the Portuguese monopoly in the East Indies → a natural-law defence of free trade.*)
- **vs Hobbes:** Grotius uses the state of nature **not to explain political authority**, but as a *device* to model the norms of the high seas.

## | Property — occupation vs *dominium*

**Core:** we have a God-given **common use-right** (occupation) by nature; **private property (*dominium*)** is a **human convention** requiring agreement and law.

- "God gave all things not to this man or that man, but to mankind." Property is "an invention of societies." The question isn't *how to justify* private property (Locke's later question) but *the conditions under which it's permissible* — with a **right of necessity** (in extreme hardship you may access another's property) that puts **natural rights above civil rights**.

## | Sociability — *appetitus societatis* (the anti-Hobbes)

**Core:** humans have a natural **desire for society** (*appetitus societatis*) — an inclination to live peaceably with their own kind. This is Grotius's fundamental break from Hobbes.

- Because man is naturally sociable, **maintaining social order is fundamental to law**. (*Critics (Haakonssen): it's a thin, "leave-others-alone" sociability — a non-interventionist account of liberty.*) We're also pushed together by **need** ("our lack of things"). Political authority arises through **voluntary agreements**; natural jurisdiction lies with the **individual**, "not a king or a pope."

## | ★ The world system of states — just war & the right to punish

**Core:** universal natural law applies **equally to states**; a **law of nations** with authority to arbitrate wars makes an ordered **society of states** — and even war is subject to law.

- ***The Rights of War and Peace* (1625):** subject international relations, incl. war, to the rule of law. War is "*an instrument of right... undertaken for the sake of peace*": **just = the execution of a right; unjust = the execution of an injury**.
- **Four just causes of war (*jus ad bellum*):** ① self-defence · ② self-preservation · ③ recovery of property / a debt · ④ punishment.

- **Restraint in war (*jus in bello*)**: a **middle ground** between Erasmus's pacifism and unlimited war — "just wars are those wherein rules are observed."
- **The right to punish** (central to international order): derived from **natural law** (not mere revenge). Against **Vitoria** (who said conquistadors *couldn't* punish the American Indians for want of jurisdiction), Grotius argues "*war may be waged against those who sin against nature*," since nature "*has jurisdiction over the whole of mankind*." But he **warns against using punitive war as a pretext** ("civilising barbarous peoples"), and punishment must be **forward-looking/deterrent**, not vengeful (Plato: "no wise man punishes because an offence was committed, but that it may not be committed again").

## Legacy

**Core:** "**father of international law**" (a title cemented by the 20th-c. jurist **Lauterpacht**; the term "international law" itself was coined by **Bentham**), and a pillar of the **social-contract tradition**.

- Influenced **Hobbes** (Tuck: Hobbes's philosophy is "a Grotian theory"), **Locke** (the natural right to **punish**), **Pufendorf**. *Contested legacy*: his **occupation/dominium** and **punishment** doctrines were later "invoked to rationalise European **empire**" — "empire is an inescapable feature of early-modern political thought."

## Key terms

| Term                                                | Meaning                                                                   |
|-----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Natural law                                         | Universal immutable principles; source = God, content = human nature      |
| Impious hypothesis ( <i>etsi Deus non daretur</i> ) | Natural law binds "even if God did not exist"                             |
| Natural (subjective) right                          | A <i>power/potestas</i> one "possesses" over oneself or a claim on others |
| <i>Suum / sui iuris</i>                             | What is one's own / subject to no one (natural liberty)                   |
| <i>Mare Liberum</i>                                 | The free sea — common to all, a "state of nature"                         |
| Occupation vs <i>dominium</i>                       | Common use-right (natural) vs private property (conventional)             |
| <i>Appetitus societatis</i>                         | The natural human desire for society (vs Hobbes)                          |
| Just war ( <i>jus ad bellum</i> )                   | 4 just causes: self-defence, self-preservation, recovery/debt, punishment |
| Right to punish                                     | Derived from natural law; enforces order among individuals & states       |
| Law of nations / society of states                  | Universal natural law applied to sovereign states                         |

## Exam pointers

- Explain the **impious hypothesis** precisely (natural law "even if God did not exist") — and the qualification (not atheism; a universality device).

- Trace the **rights chain**: *suum* → self-preservation → **property** (occupation vs *dominium*) → **punishment**.
- Use *Mare Liberum* as the worked example (sea as state of nature → free trade).
- State the **four just causes of war** + the right to punish + Grotius's **restraint** (vs Vitoria; vs Erasmus).

## ★ Hobbes vs Grotius — the module's payoff

**Core:** both are pillars of **social-contract** theory and both start from **self-preservation** — but they split on **human nature**, and that split drives everything.

|                                          | Hobbes                                                                             | Grotius                                                                               |
|------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Human nature</b>                      | Naturally in <b>conflict</b> → "war of all against all"                            | Naturally <b>sociable</b> ( <u><i>appetitus societatis</i></u> )                      |
| <u><b>Natural law</b></u>                | <b>Reduced</b> to self-security — the way <i>out</i> of the <u>state of nature</u> | Genuinely <b>obligatory</b> ; universal (binds "even if God did not exist")           |
| <u><b>State of nature</b></u> — used for | To explain the <b>origin of political authority</b>                                | Not authority <i>per se</i> — a <b>device</b> (e.g. the free seas / justifying a war) |
| <b>The sovereign &amp; the contract</b>  | Sovereign is <b>not a party</b> → no breach, (almost) no right of resistance       | Sovereign <b>can be a party</b> → a narrow right of resistance in extreme tyranny     |
| <b>Main worry</b>                        | Domestic order (avoiding civil war)                                                | <b>International</b> order (a law-governed society of states)                         |
| <b>Legacy</b>                            | Absolutism; the "science of the state"                                             | International law; natural rights; (contested) empire                                 |

*Where they meet:* Grotius's line that there's no order without enforcement echoes Hobbes's "*covenants without the sword are but breath*" — but Grotius thinks natural law + sociability can bind sovereigns **without** a world-Leviathan, which is exactly what Hobbes denies.

## ★ Fun facts & memorable details

Sticky bits from Module 2 (Hobbes & Grotius).

### Hobbes

- Life in the state of nature is "**solitary, poore, nasty, brutish, and short.**"
- The commonwealth is a "**mortal god.**"
- "**Covenants without the sword are but breath**" — Hobbes's one-line theory of international anarchy.



- **"Hobbes and Fear were born twins"** — born prematurely in **1588**, his mother's labour supposedly brought on by news of the **Spanish Armada**. Yet he was reportedly cheerful and **died at 91**; Charles II gave him a pension and enjoyed watching wits bait **"the Bear."**
- He **discovered Euclid by accident** in a gentleman's library — and built *Leviathan* like a geometry.

## Grotius

- The **impious hypothesis**: natural law would hold *"though we should even grant... that there is no God."*
- **Child prodigy**: at the University of **Leiden** **aged 11**; a law degree at ~16; Henry IV called him *"the miracle of Holland."*
- **The book-chest escape**: sentenced to life in prison, he **escaped in 1621 hidden in a chest of books**.
- The **VOC** hired him to justify seizing the Portuguese carrack *Santa Catarina* — a prize worth **~3 million guilders** ( $\approx$  the entire annual revenue of the English government that year).
- **"International law"** as a term was coined by **Bentham**; Grotius's "father of international law" title was cemented by the 20th-c. jurist **Lauterpacht**.
- He **died in 1645 after surviving a shipwreck** on the way home from serving Queen Christina of Sweden.